

Create Transparency With The Stakeholder Distance Metric

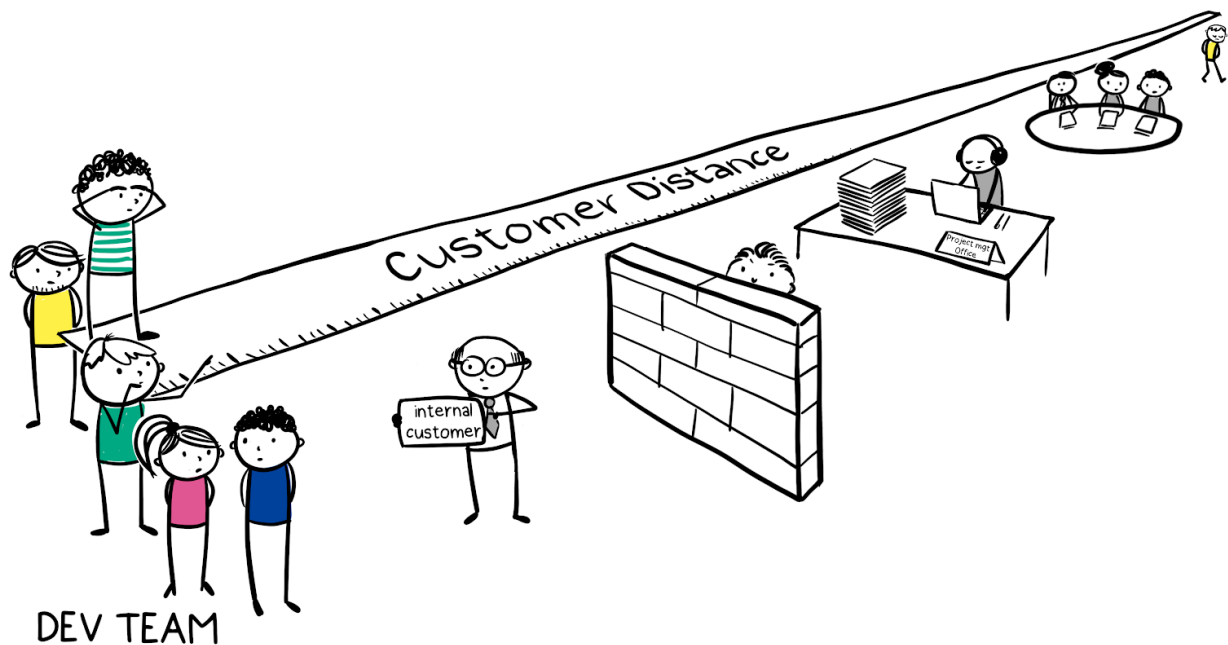
A simple experiment to measure the distance from the people building the product to the people who have clear stake in it



Purpose Of This Experiment

The Scrum Framework urges teams to involve stakeholders. But many Scrum Teams struggle to do so, and that is one of the core symptoms of Zombie Scrum. For some, involving one or two internal stakeholders seems plenty. For others, stakeholders can only be involved when the entire product is done. But without their feedback, how can you be sure that what you're building is the right thing?

This experiment is about creating transparency about the distance between developers and stakeholders and what happens because of that



Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



How much effort this requires depends on the complexity of your organization.

Impact On Survival



Probably quite painful for serious Zombie Scrum, but it will hurt in the right spots.

Steps

The Stakeholder Distance Metric tracks the average number of people, departments, or roles you have to go through ("hops") in order to convey a question or get feedback from someone who is actually paying for the product or actively using it:

1. Take a selection of items from your Product Backlog that are representative of the kind of work that your team does.
2. Taking one item at a time, draw the chain of people, departments, and roles you have to go through—or get permission from—in order to test this item with an actual stakeholder—that is, someone who is actively using your product or is investing in it significantly.
3. For each hop, come up with a rough estimate for how many hours or days it takes to go through this hop.
4. Repeat this process a couple of times for different kinds of items. Then calculate the average number of hops and the average time the hops take. For extra effect, you can calculate how much time and money is spent waiting for the chain to complete.
5. Write the number of hops and the time they take clearly on a big board or panel that is visible to all. For an extra dramatic effect, you can periodically redraw these numbers on a prominent window or wall.
6. Have a conversation with your team about what the results of this distance are. How is it affecting your team's ability to work on the right things? How much money and time is being wasted? What is going wrong because of this distance?

Teams recovering from Zombie Scrum will slowly lose their fear of stakeholders. A good way to monitor recovery is to periodically recalculate the Stakeholder Distance Metric. You can use it to drive conversations during Sprint Retrospectives on how to decrease the distance as much as possible. Many of the experiments in this book can help you do that.

Our Findings

- Metrics don't have meaning in themselves, but they are given meaning through context and conversation. Make sure that you have this conversation with your entire team. You should never use metrics to judge, compare, or evaluate teams that you yourself do not belong to;
- Shortening the distance to the stakeholder might require you to break an existing, highly elaborate product development process. Depending on your position in the system, disrupting that process might not be possible. Nevertheless, see if you can raise awareness for the problem or circumvent the issue by still talking to users and then getting involved in discussions about requirements as early as possible.

More Resources

- Actual stakeholders? Or just your audience? Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Myth: Only The Product Owner Interacts With Stakeholders. Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Involve Stakeholders](#)
- Podcast: [The Curious Case of the Missing Stakeholders](#)

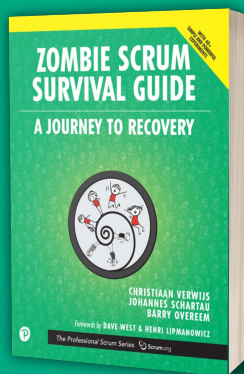
Help Us With Your Feedback



We are eager to learn how this experiment benefitted your team. What did it make possible? How did it help you make progress in your recovery from Zombie Scrum? With your data, we can improve our recommendations to other teams. You can share [your feedback](#) here with us in a only few minutes.



The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide



Zombie Scrum is on the rise! What may look like Scrum from a distance often turns out to be anything but when you take a closer look. Although teams go through the motions of Scrum, Sprints don't result in valuable outcomes, customers are not involved, teams have little autonomy and nobody is doing anything to improve.

A detailed examination of Zombie Scrum

In our book, we share our research and experience in the field with Zombie Scrum. We explore symptoms and causes, and dig deep into why Zombie Scrum usually starts when the purpose of Scrum isn't clear. With our book, the purpose of Scrum was never this clear!

Start your recovery tomorrow

The good news is that recovery is entirely possible. Our book contains over 40 practical experiments to start recovery, even when your organization has succumbed to it completely.

Get your copy now

You can find the 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' in your favorite bookstore starting from November 23, 2020. Or buy your copy from us at zombiescrum.org. The book comes with a free digital first aid kit, and a nice discount for a physical kit.



The Zombie Scrum Resistance

The 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' is written by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Schartau and Barry Overeem, and richly illustrated by Thea Schukken.

<https://zombiescrum.org>

info@zombiescrum.org